Guidelines for reviewing legal questions

Check whether each question is clear and useful, and whether the document supports what the question assumes and what the answer says. Read the example document below before reviewing the pairs. **Good**, **Bad** and their suggested scores apply only to the check being illustrated. Some examples have been adapted to show a particular problem.

Use only the supplied text, in its historical context. For EUR-Lex, explicitly linked provisions supplied with the designated article may complete it. For UN material, additional text labeled context may clarify who is speaking, but cannot supply an answer missing from the designated passage. Do not use outside research or substitute current law.

Score	Meaning
5 — Exceptional	Fully successful, with no weakness and a specific strength beyond ordinary good work. Explain that strength.
4 — Strong	Fully successful and reliable. A correct, polished result can receive 4 without any defect; a minor limitation may also fit here.
3 — Adequate	Basically useful but only serviceable, or with a meaningful limitation that does not make it unusable.
2 — Weak	A major problem requires substantial correction.
1 — Failure	The requirement is not met, or central information is missing.

Example document

Regulation (EC) No 1073/2009, Article 24 — Entry in the national electronic registers. The following is the complete article text, without its repeated heading. Use it for every example below.

Member States shall ensure that serious infringements of Community road transport legislation attributable to carriers established in their territory, which have led to the imposition of a penalty by any Member State, as well as any temporary or permanent withdrawal of the Community licence or of the certified true copy thereof are recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings. Entries in the register which concern a temporary or permanent withdrawal of a Community licence shall remain in the database for at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal, in the case of temporary withdrawal, or from the date of withdrawal, in the case of permanent withdrawal.

1. Are the question and answer supported by the text? (Grounding)

Grounding means that the document supports the answer and the factual assumptions in the question. Preserve who must act, what is required or permitted, and conditions and exceptions. A proposal is not an adopted decision. A statement presented for checking need not be true, but its answer must resolve it correctly. An important unsupported assertion merits at most **2**; no support for the central answer merits **1**.

Good — **Question:** “What must be recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings regarding carriers established in a Member State’s territory?” **Answer:** “serious infringements of Community road transport legislation attributable to carriers established in their territory, which have led to the imposition of a penalty by any Member State, as well as any temporary or permanent withdrawal of the Community licence or of the certified true copy thereof” **Score: 4/5.** The answer preserves every listed category and relevant condition.

Bad — **Question:** “What must be recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings regarding carriers established in a Member State’s territory?” **Answer:** “Only temporary withdrawals of the Community licence are recorded; permanent withdrawals are excluded.” **Score: 2/5.** It falsely excludes permanent withdrawals and omits serious infringements.

2. Does the answer include the right amount of evidence? (Precision)

Precision means including the evidence needed to answer the question, with essential qualifications and no unnecessary material. Keep conditions and exceptions, even if they lengthen the answer. Use one unbroken passage; identify a shorter sufficient passage before penalizing excess. A missing essential qualification merits at most **2**; absence of the main information merits **1**. Judge this separately from factual correctness.

Good — **Question:** "How long must entries concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence remain in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 4/5.** The passage includes the minimum duration and starting event.

Bad — **Question:** "How long must entries concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence remain in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years" **Score: 2/5.** The answer omits when the two-year period starts.

3. Are numbers and references accurate? (Numerical fidelity)

Numerical fidelity means preserving numbers and references accurately, including their meaning in context. Check dates, units, percentages, limits and the event from which a period runs. A changed value or meaning merits at most **2**; an invented or contradicted central value merits **1**. Hypothetical values and values proposed for checking are not automatically errors. If no relevant number or reference occurs, record **4 and "not applicable"**.

Good — **Question:** "What is the minimum retention period for entries in the national electronic register concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence?" **Answer:** "for at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 4/5.** The two-year minimum and its starting event match exactly.

Bad — **Question:** "What is the minimum retention period for entries in the national electronic register concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence?" **Answer:** "for at least 5 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 1/5.** The document specifies a two-year minimum; the answer changes it to five years.

4. Would an expert reasonably need this information? (Search realism)

Search realism is the plausibility of a question as a real request for information. Judge whether it serves a recognizable legal need, rather than tests recognition of words. Simple requests can be useful; give no extra credit for length, difficulty or public importance. A plausible need merits **4**; a largely pointless request merits **1–2**.

Good — **Question:** "What events must be recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "serious infringements of Community road transport legislation attributable to carriers established in their territory, which have led to the imposition of a penalty by any Member State, as well as any temporary or permanent withdrawal of the Community licence or of the certified true copy thereof" **Score: 4/5.** An expert could use this to check recording duties.

Bad — **Question:** "Which word immediately precedes 'licence' in the first sentence?" **Answer:** "Community" **Score: 1/5.** Finding a nearby word serves no legal information need.

5. Is the question understandable on its own? (Standalone clarity)

Standalone clarity means the question can be understood without seeing the source document. Check that it identifies the legal setting, actors and information sought. Require conditions, territory or time only when necessary. Sufficient context merits **4**; broad but usable context may merit **3**. Missing an essential distinction merits at most **2**; an unidentifiable subject merits **1**.

Good — **Question:** "How long must entries concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence remain in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 4/5.** The question identifies the licence, withdrawal type and register.

Bad — **Question:** "For how long must these entries remain there?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 1/5.** Neither "these entries" nor "there" identifies the subject independently.

6. Does the answer provide the information asked for? (Information value)

Information value is the extent to which the answer provides what the question asks for. Check that it addresses every requested part. A retention period does not identify which entries must be recorded. Repeating the question does not answer it. A complete response merits **4**; a useful answer with a small omission may merit **3**. A missing important part merits at most **2**; absent central information merits **1**.

Good — **Question:** "Which entries must Member States ensure are recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "serious infringements of Community road transport legislation attributable to carriers established in their territory, which have led to the imposition of a penalty by any Member State, as well as any temporary or permanent withdrawal of the Community licence or of the certified true copy thereof" **Score: 4/5.** It identifies all entries the text requires to be recorded.

Bad — **Question:** "Which entries must Member States ensure are recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 1/5.** It gives a duration, not the requested recording categories.

7. Does the question make one clear, focused request? (Focus and formulation)

Focus and formulation describe how clearly a question expresses one purpose, using only the wording needed. Allow connected parts, but require a clear request rather than a list of topics. Avoid unnecessary background and extensive copying of ordinary source wording. Keep necessary legal terms; do not penalize answers for quoting. A focused question merits **4**; loose wording may merit **3**; a diffuse request merits **1–2**.

Good — **Question:** "What is the minimum retention period for entries in the national electronic register concerning a temporary withdrawal of a Community licence?" **Answer:** "for at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 4/5.** It asks only for the minimum retention period for entries concerning temporary withdrawal.

Bad — **Question:** "What about registers, carriers, penalties, licences and withdrawal?" **Answer:** "Member States shall ensure that serious infringements of Community road transport legislation attributable to carriers established in their territory, which have led to the imposition of a penalty by any Member State, as well as any temporary or permanent withdrawal of the Community licence or of the certified true copy thereof are recorded in the national electronic register of road transport undertakings." **Score: 2/5.** It lists several topics without specifying what information is sought.

8. Is the language clear and natural? (Linguistic quality)

Linguistic quality is the correctness and naturalness of the question's language. Assess grammar, sentence structure and terminology in the original language for a reader with appropriate legal knowledge. Correct professional writing merits **4**; understandable but awkward wording may merit **3**; language that seriously hinders understanding merits **1–2**. Do not lower this score solely for a factual error or old-fashioned wording in a quoted source.

Good — **Question:** "How long must entries concerning temporary withdrawal of a Community licence remain in the national electronic register?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 4/5.** The grammar and legal terminology are clear and natural.

Bad — **Question:** "How long entries of temporary withdraw a Community licence is must stay in national electronic register?" **Answer:** "at least 2 years from the time of the expiry of the period of withdrawal" **Score: 2/5.** Several grammatical errors make the sentence difficult to read.

Record your judgments

Record all eight scores and brief reasons. Explain scores of **1–2 and 5**, and the basis for **3**. Correctness alone does not justify 5, and no quota applies. If missing material or insufficient expertise prevents assessment, record **cannot assess** and explain why. A known error is not unassessable. Good writing cannot compensate for unsupported content.

Qualification test: understanding the task

Annotator ID: _____ Date: _____

Choose **exactly one answer (A–D)** for each question and circle your choice. You may consult this guide; work independently. Submit the test for review before beginning annotation.

1. For an item you can assess, what must you record?

A. One overall 1–5 score; **B.** Eight scores without reasons; **C.** Eight 1–5 scores, reasons and needed corrections; **D.** A rewritten question and answer only.

2. How should you distinguish scores 4 and 5?

A. 4: fully successful; 5: an explained exceptional strength; **B.** 4: flawed; 5: error-free; **C.** 4: simple; 5: difficult; **D.** 4 and 5 mean the same thing.

3. How should an important unsupported assertion affect scoring?

A. Give every criterion 1; **B.** Give Grounding 3 and leave other scores unchanged; **C.** Mark every criterion "cannot assess"; **D.** Give Grounding at most 2; judge other criteria separately.

4. No relevant numbers or references apply. What do you record for Numerical fidelity?

A. 1; **B.** 4 and "not applicable"; **C.** 5; **D.** "Cannot assess".

5. When should you use "cannot assess"?

A. The answer is known to be unsupported; **B.** The wording is poor; **C.** Any score would be below 4; **D.** Needed material or expertise is missing; explain why.

6. What do you use to judge factual support and Linguistic quality, respectively?

A. Supplied text; the question's original language; **B.** Supplied text; an English translation only; **C.** Outside sources; the original language; **D.** Outside sources; an English translation only.

7. When checking whether a question stands on its own, how should you handle missing context?

A. Fill it in from the document; **B.** Assume the most likely subject; **C.** Judge only the information in the question; **D.** Ignore missing context if the grammar is correct.

8. Before lowering a score because an answer is too long, what should you check?

A. Whether it exceeds a fixed word limit; **B.** Whether a shorter continuous passage preserves all needed information and qualifications; **C.** Whether another answer is shorter; **D.** Whether technical terms can be removed.

9. What should a useful explanation of a score include?

A. The score number repeated in words; **B.** A general impression such as "good" or "bad"; **C.** A specific strength or problem relevant to that criterion; **D.** A comparison with the previous item.

10. What should you do when an answer provides only part of the requested information?

A. Give full marks because the supplied facts are correct; **B.** Identify what is missing and lower the affected scores appropriately; **C.** Give every criterion 1; **D.** Use "cannot assess" for every criterion.